

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 6 OF 12

The Open Door

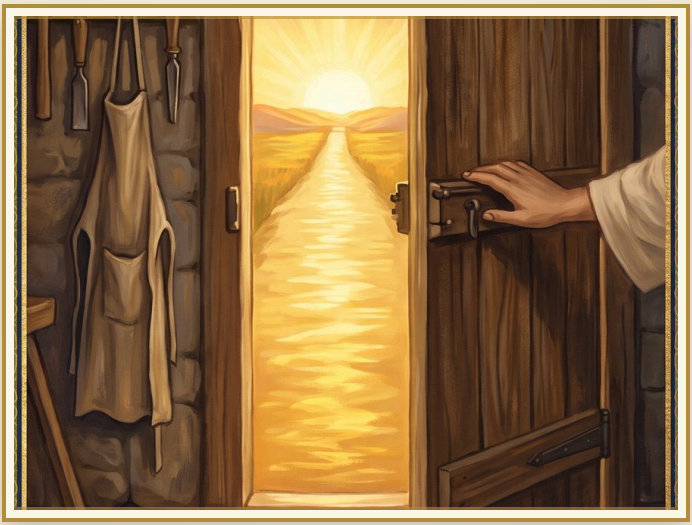
FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For the one whose work has ended, and who still has so much to give.



Father Lucas



BOOK 6

This book: Work, retirement, and being of use. The door behind you has closed. Mary stays beside you while you look for the one that opens.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

The Year of Untied Knots · Days 153–183

Knot of the month: Work (and, along the way, forgiveness and the money that comes from honest hands).

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

My friend,

Five months of mornings. Look at that. Some days you prayed with the coffee gone cold, and you prayed anyway. That counts for more than you think. Mary noticed.

This month is about work. Not only jobs. The work you did for forty years, the work that ended, the work you wish somebody would ask you to do. When a door like that closes, it is a real grief. I won't call it small.

But I have stood at a great many doors. Most of them open slowly, and from the inside.

Bring your hands. Bring the old résumé, the retirement card, the empty afternoon. Mary lived beside a carpenter. She knows a workshop when she sees one.

Father Lucas

THE MONTH AT A GLANCE

Week 1 · Days 153–159: Name the door that closed, then ask for the next step only, never the whole staircase.

Week 2 · Days 160–166: Your worth was never the paycheck. Find the small work still yours, and forgive what hurt you.

Week 3 · Days 167–173: Face the fear of being replaced, knock again, and give your gifts away for free.

Week 4 · Days 174–183: Rest without guilt, let go of the wrong doors, say thank you, and light the candle.

BOOK 6

THREE PROMISES FOR THE MONTH

I. *I will ask for the next step only, not the whole road.*

II. *I will do one useful thing today, paid or not.*

III. *I will remember I am more than what I was paid to be.*

MY NAME



THE PSALM OF THE MONTH

"Open to me the gates of righteousness. I will enter into them. I will give thanks to Yah. This is the gate of the LORD; the righteous will enter into it." — Psalm 118:19-20 (WEB)

Say it each time you pass through a doorway this month.

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WEEK 1

Week 1

DAYS 153 TO 159

Name the door that closed, then ask for the next step only, never the whole staircase.

153

DAY 153

The Door That Closed

May the LORD answer you in the day of trouble. May the name of the God of Jacob set you up on high,

PSALM 20:1 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Maybe a door closed on you. A job, a shop, a title, a desk with your name on it. Maybe it closed years ago and you still feel the draft.

I won't make it smaller than it is. Ask yourself what you miss most. It's rarely the paycheck. It's the sound of your name said by someone who needed something done. When that stops, the house goes quiet in a new way.

Today we don't knock. We only look at the door and say what it was. Mary has stood outside closed doors herself.

Mother Mary, here is the door that closed. I'm standing in front of it with my coffee going cold. I miss being needed. I miss the hum of the place, and the sound of my own name. Don't hurry me past it. Sit with me in this kitchen, and when I'm ready, show me one step I can take. Amen.



TODAY

Write one sentence that begins, "The door that closed was..." Say it plainly, the way you'd tell an old friend. Leave the paper on the kitchen table.

☐ DONE

What did that work give me that I haven't named yet?

PSALM

20 — a blessing for the day of trouble; read it when work has closed behind you.

154

DAY 154

Joseph Rose Early

Early in the morning, while it was still dark, he rose up and went out, and departed into a deserted place, and prayed there.

MARK 1:35 (WEB)

There was a workshop in Nazareth. I like to picture it: cut wood, oil, shavings under his sandals. Joseph got up early and put his hands to something. Most days, that was the whole holiness of it.

You may not have a bench anymore. You still have hands and a morning, and the morning isn't empty just because the calendar is.

Look at your hands, front and back. They knew what to do for years without being told. They didn't retire when you did. They're only waiting to be asked.

Mary lived beside a man who rose for work. Rise anyway. Let the day find you already standing.

Lord Jesus, you grew up in a workshop. You know the sound of a saw before the sun is up. I'm awake and I have nowhere to be. Meet me here. Teach my hands to be useful again, even if the work is small and nobody pays me for it. Give this morning a shape. Tell me what to pick up first. Amen.



TODAY

Rest both hands palm-up on your lap for one full minute. Look at them. Then say quietly, "These hands have worked, and they can work today."

☐ DONE

What is one thing my hands know how to do without thinking?

PSALM

5 — the morning psalm: he hears your voice, and you watch.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A week without this page and the old heaviness comes back. It doesn't announce itself. One afternoon you just notice you're sighing at the window again. Come back tomorrow, even for a minute.



DAY 155

Ask for the Next Step

Show me your ways, the LORD. Teach me your paths. Guide me in your truth, and teach me, for you are the God of my salvation. I wait for you all day long.

PSALM 25:4-5 (WEB)

Everybody wants the whole map. Where will the money come from? Who hires a person my age? What do I do with the rest of my life? Those are real questions. But nobody can answer them before breakfast.

Years ago, Patricia and Dale, from Dayton, sat at their table with a pile of worry. I asked them for one thing: what is the next step, only the next? Dale said, "Call about the hours." That was all. It was enough for that day.

Mary doesn't hand you the staircase. She holds the lamp over the first stair.

Mary, I don't need to see the whole road. I need to see the next step. Here is the question I keep asking: what now? I put it in your hands. Show me one thing to do before noon, small enough to carry. Quiet the rest. When the worry says "what about next year," remind me that next year isn't here yet. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, in your own kitchen voice, "Show me the next step. Only the next one." Say it three times, slower each time, then listen for a moment.

☐ DONE

If the next step were small, what would it be?

PSALM

25 — "Show me your ways": asking for guidance one step at a time.



DAY 156

A Résumé of Your Life

God, you have taught me from my youth. Until now, I have declared your wondrous works.

PSALM 71:17 (WEB)

The résumé in the old folder is short. Two pages, maybe one. Job titles, dates, a phone number from another decade. It doesn't say what you really did.

It doesn't say you stayed late to fix what somebody else broke. It doesn't say you talked a frightened new hire through her first week. It doesn't say you raised children on the side, or buried a parent, and still showed up on time. That is the true résumé.

God has kept it. Not in a folder. In his memory. Today, read your life the way he does.

Lord, you were there for all of it. The early shifts and the long drives. The days I did it badly and the days I did it well. I don't want to hide my years this morning. I want to see them. Remind me of one thing I did that mattered, and let me thank you for it. Amen.



TODAY

Write five short lines: five things you did well in your working life. No job titles. Just what your hands or your head actually did.

☐ DONE

Which of those five would I be proud to teach someone?

PSALM

71 — "You have taught me from my youth": a psalm for looking back with thanks.



DAY 157

Dignity Is Not a Paycheck



For you have made him a little lower than the angels, and crowned him with glory and honor.

PSALM 8:5 (WEB)

There's a quiet lie that goes around when the paychecks stop. It says, you were worth what they paid you. And now that nobody pays you, what are you?

Let me answer, because I've heard that question too many times to stay silent. You are crowned. The psalm says it plainly. God made you and put glory on your head long before anybody gave you a title.

No boss handed you that, and no boss can take it back. The nameplate was a loan. Now thank the things that carried you: the shoes, the pen, the chair.

Father, I've been measuring myself by a number that stopped arriving. Forgive me for believing that number. Tell me again who I am before the job, and after it. Let me stand a little straighter at the sink this morning. Let me look at my own face and see what you see. Give me back my own name, plain and whole. Amen.



TODAY

Say "thank you" out loud to three things you worked with: a tool, a chair, a pair of shoes, a pen. They carried you, too.

☐ DONE

Where did I first learn that I was worth only what I earned?

PSALM

8 — you are small, and you are crowned; read it when you feel like nobody.



DAY 158

The Interview of the Heart

Examine me, LORD, and prove me. Try my heart and my mind. For your loving kindness is before my eyes. I have walked in your truth.

PSALM 26:2-3 (WEB)

You've probably sat in an interview chair. Folded hands, a smile you rehearsed, answers you hoped were the right ones. It's tiring to be asked what you can do for someone else.

Here is an interview with no tricks. God sits across from you, and he isn't checking your references. He has already read them. The psalmist says, "Examine me." He wasn't afraid, because he knew who was asking.

Today you don't answer. You sit, and you let him look. That's the whole interview. I've never known anyone to walk out of it feeling smaller.

Lord Jesus, here I am in the chair. No résumé. No rehearsed smile. Look at what's in me: the fear, the pride, the small quiet hope. Keep what is good. Gently take what isn't. Stay as long as it takes. I'm too tired to pretend this morning. Let your look be kind, as I believe it is. Amen.



TODAY

Sit in your favorite chair until the clock has moved five minutes. Say nothing. Let him look. When you stand, say only, "Thank you for the interview."

☐ DONE

What would I be glad for God to find in me today?

PSALM

26 — "Examine me": an honest psalm for a person who has nothing to hide from a friend.



DAY 159

Who Needs You Today



Let's consider how to provoke one another to love and good works,

HEBREWS 10:24 (WEB)

Here is a secret about a lost job or a long retirement. The first thing that goes isn't the money. It's being asked. Nobody calls to find out what you think. Nobody needs the one thing only you know how to do.

So let's turn it around. Somebody in your phone is carrying something today. A friend from the old shop, a cousin, a neighbor having a bad week. They may not say so. They may be waiting for you to call first.

Being needed isn't a job. It's a phone call. You can make it before the coffee is cold.

Our Lady, show me who needs me today. Not someone grand. Someone small and near. Let me hear what they aren't saying. Give me the nerve to dial, and the sense to listen more than I talk. If it's only five minutes, let it be five good ones. I'm still of use. Teach me how. Let whoever answers be glad I called. Amen.



TODAY

Call a neighbor or an old friend and ask, "Do you need anything from the store today?" Then listen to whatever they say next.

☐ DONE

Who in my phone would be glad to hear my voice today?

PSALM

68 — "God sets the lonely in families": read it after the call.



WEEK 2

Your worth was never the paycheck

DAYS 160 TO 166

Find the small work still yours, and forgive what hurt you.



DAY 160

Small Work, Large Love



For you will eat the labor of your hands. You will be happy, and it will be well with you.

PSALM 128:2 (WEB)

Mrs. Doyle has cleaned our church for twenty years. Nobody has ever given her a plaque. She polishes the ends of the pews on her knees, one by one, and hums when she thinks no one is near.

I asked her once why she took such care with parts nobody sees. She said, "Father, somebody sits there." That was all. Somebody sits there.

Work is made large by who it's for. A sink of dishes for people you love is bigger than an office for people you don't. You still have that kind of work. Do it as though somebody will sit there.

Lord, make my small work large with love. The cup I wash, the bed I make, the floor I sweep. Bless the hands behind every ordinary thing. Let none of it be filler between better things. Let me do it as if you were the guest at my table. And when I feel useless, remind me that somebody sits there. Amen.



TODAY

Wash one cup or plate by hand, slowly, as if someone you love will use it. When you set it down, whisper, "For you."

☐ DONE

What small task of mine does somebody quietly depend on?

PSALM

128 — "You will eat the labor of your hands": a psalm for the dignity of ordinary work.



DAY 161

Tools on the Bench

A man shall be satisfied with good by the fruit of his mouth. The work of a man's hands shall be rewarded to him.

PROVERBS 12:14 (WEB)

Go to the garage, or the hall closet, or the bottom of the sewing basket. Find the tool you used the most. A hammer with a worn handle. Good scissors. A ring of keys to a shop that isn't yours now. A pen that signed a lot of things.

Hold it. Feel how your hand still fits.

Joseph's tools hung on a wall in Nazareth. They weren't useless on the days he wasn't working. They waited. Yours have been waiting too. Put one where you can see it. Not as a souvenir. As a reminder that you are a person who makes things.

Here is the tool my hands remember, Lord. Thank you for the years it served, and the people it fed. Bless the work I did with it, the good and the clumsy. And if there is more to be made with these hands, set my mind to it. Let the work of my hands bring its reward, as the old book promises. Amen.



TODAY

Take one tool you used all your working life and set it where your eyes land first in the morning. Touch it once as you pass.

☐ DONE

What would these hands make if nobody were grading it?

PSALM

90 — "Establish the work of our hands": the psalm for anyone who ever built, mended, or cooked.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A door that's open a crack can drift shut if nobody leans on it. So can a knot you've loosened. Come back tomorrow, only for a minute, and lean on it a little.



DAY 162

A Call to an Old Colleague



Two are better than one, because they have a good reward for their labor.

ECCLESIASTES 4:9 (WEB)

You haven't talked to him since the last day. Or her. The one at the next desk, in the next truck, at the end of the lunch table. You meant to call. Weeks became a year. Now it feels like too long to start.

It isn't. People who worked beside you remember the odd things: your laugh, how you took your coffee, the day you helped. They rarely remember the silence. They only wonder if you're all right.

Two are better than one, says the Preacher. Make the call small. Say your name. The rest will come on its own.

Holy Mother, thank you for the people I worked beside. Some made me laugh. Some made me angry. All of them knew a side of me my family never saw. Give me the nerve to dial that number. Give me easy words. And let whoever answers feel, for a moment, remembered. That is a kind of work, too. Amen.



TODAY

Call one person from your working years and ask only, "How are you, really?" If nobody answers, leave a short message with your name.

☐ DONE

What is one thing I never thanked anyone for at work?

PSALM

15 — "nor does evil to his friend": honest hands, and an honest word to a friend.

163

DAY 163

Retirement Is Not Retreat

So Abram went, as the LORD had told him. Lot went with him. Abram was seventy-five years old when he departed from Haran.

GENESIS 12:4 (WEB)

Retirement can feel like a door closing softly behind you. Everyone says congratulations. Then the house goes quiet.

Walt ushered at our church for thirty years. The week he retired, he stopped coming. He told me, "What's an usher with nothing to carry?" I knocked on his door with a bulletin and asked him to walk the block with me. He did. Then he walked it every day, greeting everybody on it. Within a month the block knew him better than the pews ever had.

Abram was seventy-five when he packed up and went. Seventy-five is not the end of the story. Sometimes it's chapter two.

Lord, I don't want to retire into a chair. I don't want to retreat into the television. Walk with me this morning. Show me the street, the people, the small errands that need a body with time. Let this slower life be a different kind of calling, not the end of one. Open the door, and I will go out. Amen.



TODAY

Walk once around the block and say one Hail Mary at each corner. Greet anyone you pass by looking up and nodding.

☐ DONE

What did I do at work that I secretly wish I could keep doing?

PSALM

119 — a long walk through his word, for someone who is still walking.



DAY 164

The Skill You Forgot

> *For the gifts and the calling of God are irrevocable.*
>
> ROMANS 11:29 (WEB)

You used to be good at something. Not the job. Something underneath it. Fixing a sticking door. Calming a crying child. Making a room feel welcome. Keeping a long column of numbers honest.

Somewhere along the way you stopped counting it as a skill, because it never got a line on a form.

Paul says the gifts of God are irrevocable. They can't be taken back, not by age, not by a layoff, not by forgetting. They hang in you like a good coat in a closet, still your size. Take one out today. Put your arms in the sleeves.

Father, you gave me a gift and never asked for it back. Forgive me for burying it under "I'm too old" and "nobody needs that now." Remind me what I'm good at. Bring it to mind this morning, and show me one small place to use it today. Let it be of use to somebody. Amen.



TODAY

Write down one thing you were good at that never made it onto a form. Then write the name of one person who could use it this week.

☐ DONE

Who could use the thing I forgot I was good at?

PSALM

138 — "Do not forsake the works of your hands": for the gift that went quiet.



DAY 165

Hands Made for Giving

But don't forget to be doing good and sharing, for with such sacrifices God is well pleased.

HEBREWS 13:16 (WEB)

Look in the closets. Look in the garage. Somewhere there's a good tool, a heavy pot, a coat, a box of yarn that you haven't touched in a year. It's sitting there being polite.

I know you worry about what you can offer now. You aren't earning. You can't write the big check. But your hands are still made for giving, and some of what they can give is already in your house.

The thing you no longer use is exactly what someone else has been waiting for. Giving it away is work. It's the oldest and most honest kind.

Mother Mary, you gave with open hands. I want to learn that. Show me what to let go of, and who it's for. Take away the small tight voice that says I might need it someday. Make my house a little lighter and someone else's a little fuller. And bless whoever receives it, and the hands that open it. Amen.



TODAY

Give away one thing you haven't used in a year: a tool, a pan, a book, a coat. Set it by the door and decide who gets it.

☐ DONE

What do I own that someone else is missing?

PSALM

112 — the one who gives freely; for hands that are done earning and still full.

166

DAY 166

A Boss, a Neighbor, an Enemy

If it is possible, as much as it is up to you, be at peace with all men.

ROMANS 12:18 (WEB)

Some of the worst wounds in a working life weren't the layoff. They were a person. A boss who spoke to you like furniture. A co-worker who talked behind your back. Someone who got the promotion you earned and smiled about it.

I won't tell you it didn't matter. It did. But I'll tell you what I've seen. A hurt kept inside grows. It eats the appetite, the sleep, the good morning.

Paul says, if it is possible, as much as it is up to you. He knows it isn't always possible. He only asks for your part. Today, your part is a name.

Lord Jesus, you know who I'm thinking of. I'm not ready to hug them. I'm not even ready to forgive. But I'm ready to say their name without spitting it. Give me a little more room for them. Let my part be as small as it needs to be, and as honest. I'll start there. Amen.



TODAY

Say the name of the person who hurt you at work, out loud, in an empty room. Then say, "I'm willing to be willing."

☐ DONE

What would it cost me to put this down for one day?

PSALM

103 — "He forgives all your sins": mercy enough for you and for them.



WEEK 3

Week 3

DAYS 167 TO 173

Face the fear of being replaced, knock again, and give your gifts away for free.

167

DAY 167

Fear of Being Replaced

But as for me, I am like a green olive tree in God's house. I trust in God's loving kindness forever and ever.

PSALM 52:8 (WEB)

There's a new young person at the counter. Or a machine, or a form that doesn't need you. Or you've simply heard the news: someone is learning your job. The fear arrives quietly and then sits in your stomach all day.

I know this fear. When I was young I was afraid the next priest would be better than me. He was, at some things. I did not disappear.

The psalm gives you a picture: a green olive tree in God's house. A tree isn't replaced when another tree grows beside it. It's rooted. It does its own growing. Your worth has roots, and roots don't fill out applications.

Gentle Mother, I'm afraid there's no place left for me. Afraid that someone younger, faster, cheaper will take what I did. I give you that fear. Plant me in your Son's house like a green tree. Let my roots go deeper than any job. And when the worry speaks, help me answer it with thanks. Amen.



TODAY

Write down one thing you do that is yours alone: a way of explaining, a joke, a casserole nobody else gets right. Tape it where you'll see it today.

☐ DONE

What part of me can no one replace?

PSALM

52 — "a green olive tree in God's house": rooted, and not easily replaced.



DAY 168

Honest Pay, Honest Thanks

Also that every man should eat and drink, and enjoy good in all his labor, is the gift of God.

ECCLESIASTES 3:13 (WEB)

Think of the last check you earned. Or the last envelope from the pension. Or the small bill you gave a neighbor for fixing something. Did you say thank you for it? Not to the boss. To God.

We forget. The money arrives, and the bills ask for it before we've even looked at it. But Ecclesiastes says to enjoy good in all your labor is a gift of God. A gift. Not a prize, and not a paycheck.

Honest work, honest pay, an honest meal at the end of it. Say thanks for that today. It won't fix the bills. It will fix your eyes.

Father, thank you for every honest dollar I ever earned. Thank you for the people who paid me fairly, and forgive me for resenting the ones who didn't. Bless the money I have now, small or large. Teach me to count it with gratitude and spend it with care. Keep me from shame about what I lack. Amen.



TODAY

Bless your next meal out loud, and name the work that put it on your plate: the farmer, the driver, the cashier, your own.

☐ DONE

Whose honest work do I enjoy every day without thanking them?

PSALM

37 — "A little that the righteous has": enough, with a clear conscience.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Today's thanks covers today's bread. Tomorrow's bills won't care that you were grateful yesterday. So give thanks again tomorrow, short and plain, before the mail comes.



DAY 169

Pray Over the Application

Commit your deeds to the LORD, and your plans shall succeed.

PROVERBS 16:3 (WEB)

Maybe it's a job application. Maybe it's a form for a benefit, a volunteer sign-up, a loan for the roof. Whatever it is, you've been putting it off, because the questions feel like small insults, and the blank lines look so long. Date of birth. Last employer. Reason for leaving.

My grandmother laid her hand on every important paper and prayed over it. She wasn't superstitious. She was telling God, this one is yours too.

Commit your deeds, the proverb says. It doesn't say the form will behave. It says you don't fill it out alone.

My hand is on this form, Lord, and it is shaking a little. Help me answer without shame. Let me say true things about my years in plain words. Steady my pen. Whatever comes of this paper, don't let me fill it out alone. Go with it to whoever reads it, and let them see a person, not just a date. Amen.



TODAY

Lay your hand flat on one application, form, or letter you have been avoiding. Say its name out loud. Then fill in only the first line.

☐ DONE

What am I afraid the paper will say about me?

PSALM

31 — "My times are in your hand": for a person waiting on an answer.

170

DAY 170

Your Kitchen Is a Parish

Unless the LORD builds the house, they who build it labor in vain. Unless the LORD watches over the city, the watchman guards it in vain.

PSALM 127:1 (WEB)

A parish is a place where people are fed, listened to, and sent out better than they came. Look at your kitchen. A kettle. A table. Chairs.

How many people have sat there? A grandchild with homework. A neighbor with news. You, with a letter you couldn't bear to read. You were doing parish work all those years and calling it supper.

You don't need a title or a building. The Lord builds the house, the psalm says. He has been building this one for a long time. Your layoff or your retirement hasn't closed it. It has only changed the hours.

Lord Jesus, bless this kitchen. The stove, the sink, the chairs that have held my weight and other people's sorrow. Let anyone who walks in find something warm. Let me be a gentle presence here, even on tired days. Build this house the way only you can, one visit at a time. Let it still feel like home. Amen.



TODAY

Clear one square foot of a counter and put one candle or Bible there. Call it your altar. Touch it each time you pass today.

☐ DONE

Who is the next person I'd like to see sitting at this table?

PSALM

127 — "Unless the LORD builds the house": for the home that has always been work.

171

DAY 171

Knocking Is Also Praying

He also spoke a parable to them that they must always pray and not give up,

LUKE 18:1 (WEB)

There's a kind of tired that comes from knocking. You've sent the letters. Called the numbers. Made yourself presentable for rooms that never answered. Now you wonder if it's pride to keep going.

Jesus says pray always and don't give up. He doesn't say once. He doesn't give you a number. He says it as plainly as a man tells you to turn off the stove.

Here is what I want you to hear. The knocking is itself a prayer. Every attempt is a small act of hope. Even the ones nobody answers. God hears every single knock.

Mary, my knuckles are sore. I've knocked on so many doors that stayed shut. Let me knock again, but not out of panic. Let me knock like someone who believes there's a person at home. Hear every attempt, even the ones I'm ashamed of. I'm still here, and I'm still hoping. Open what you will, when you will. Amen.



TODAY

Knock softly three times on your own front door or kitchen table. After each knock, whisper, "Lord." Then rest your palm on the wood.

☐ DONE

What have I stopped knocking on because I got tired?

PSALM

24 — "Lift up your heads, you gates": the psalm of doors that open for a King.



DAY 172

Mentor Someone

The things which you have heard from me among many witnesses, commit the same things to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.

2 TIMOTHY 2:2 (WEB)

You know things nobody wrote down. How to read a customer's face before he speaks. How to fix a hinge with a bent nail. When to stay quiet in a meeting. That isn't in any manual. When you leave, it leaves with you.

A young person somewhere doesn't know it yet. They're making the mistakes you made, learning them the hard way, alone.

Paul told Timothy to hand on what he'd heard, to people who would hand it on again. That is mentoring. It doesn't need a program. It needs a phone and ten honest minutes.

Lord, thank you for those who taught me. Their names come back slowly: a foreman, a teacher, an aunt. Let me pass on what I learned, without bossing and without boring. Send me one young person who needs it. Teach me to listen first. Let my years be good for something. Bless them, wherever they are. Amen.



TODAY

Call a younger relative or neighbor and offer to teach them one thing you know. Choose the thing now, and offer it in one sentence.

☐ DONE

What do I know that took me years to learn?

PSALM

145 — "One generation will commend your works to another": a psalm for handing things on.



DAY 173

The Unpaid Vocation



As each has received a gift, employ it in serving one another, as good managers of the grace of God in its various forms.

1 PETER 4:10 (WEB)

Some of the best work in the world has no pay. Sitting with a lonely neighbor. Driving a friend to an appointment she's scared of. Making soup for the family down the street. Nobody writes it on a résumé. Heaven keeps the books.

Tom lives alone, two doors down from me. Years ago I noticed the only person who spoke to him all week was the mailman. So I sat on his front step for ten minutes and said nothing clever. He talked about his dog. That was it. We did it again.

Peter says each of us has a gift to serve with. Yours may be listening.

Our Lady, give me work that no one pays me for. Show me the ones who are lonely on my own street. Let my time be a gift, not a favor. Let me listen with my whole face, and stay a little longer than is polite. I want to be of use to someone today. Amen.



TODAY

Give ten quiet minutes to someone lonely. On the phone, on a step, in your kitchen. Say little. Ask one question, then hear the whole answer.

☐ DONE

Who near me has gone longest without being listened to?

PSALM

82 — "Defend the weak": a psalm for work that nobody pays for.



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 174 TO 183

Rest without guilt, let go of the wrong doors, say thank you, and light the candle.



DAY 174

Rest Without Guilt

On the seventh day God finished his work which he had done; and he rested on the seventh day from all his work which he had done.

GENESIS 2:2 (WEB)

I took my first real nap late in life, and I felt guilty for a week. A grown man, asleep in the afternoon, with letters still unanswered. I thought somebody would knock and catch me.

Nobody knocked. The letters waited. The world went on without me, and was fine.

God rested. In the very first chapter of the Bible, after the biggest job ever done, he rested. He didn't rest because he was lazy, and he didn't apologize. If rest was good enough for him, it's good enough for your tired back.

Lord, I've worked so long that stopping feels like a sin. Help me put things down without apologizing. Let this chair be a holy place for the next few minutes. Thank you for the permission. Let my body learn that I'm not paid by the hour in your house. Rest me, Lord. Rest me all the way down. Amen.



TODAY

Sit with your coffee and say nothing for two full minutes. If a to-do list wanders in, nod politely and let it keep walking.

☐ DONE

What would I do today if I weren't afraid of looking idle?

PSALM

1 — "like a tree planted by the streams of water": a tree doesn't hurry, and it still bears fruit.



DAY 175

The Wrong Door

A man's heart plans his course,
but the LORD directs his steps.

PROVERBS 16:9 (WEB)

Look back at the door you were so sure about. The offer that fell through. The interview that went nowhere. The business you gave years to. At the time it felt like the only door in the world.

It closed, and it hurt, and you're still angry.

Now let me say something gently. Sometimes the door that didn't open was never yours. Not every closed door is a punishment. Some are a mercy, and you won't know it for years. A person plans his course, the proverb says, but the Lord directs his steps. Let him direct yours.

There's a door I still can't forgive for closing, Lord. I wanted it so much. Help me lay it down. If it was the wrong door, thank you for shutting it. If I'm not sure, thank you anyway. Turn my eyes from what's behind me to what's in front. Keep my steps in your hands. I trust you more than my plans. Amen.



TODAY

Put one object that stands for the door you lost, a badge, a business card, a letter, into a small box. Close the lid.

☐ DONE

What if the closed door was kinder than it felt?

PSALM

16 — "You will show me the path of life": for steps you didn't choose.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I carried a lost post in my chest for years. Every time I thought it was gone, it tightened again. Put it down today. Then tomorrow, put it down again. That's how it's done.

176

DAY 176

When the Phone Finally Rings

But most certainly, God has listened. He has heard the voice of my prayer. Blessed be God, who has not turned away my prayer, nor his loving kindness from me.

PSALM 66:19-20 (WEB)

One day it may ring. An unknown number, a polite voice, a question about your availability. Or a neighbor asking for a hand. I have seen people find the phone ringing after a long silence. Not every time, and never on schedule. But I've seen it.

When it does, you'll need two things: a calm voice, and a heart that already said yes to God. Don't wait for the call to practice either one.

The psalmist says God has listened. He says it as a fact, not a hope. He heard every word you prayed this month. Now practice answering.

Lord, if the phone rings today, let me answer in a clear voice. Not a pleading one. Not a defeated one. Let me say my name like someone who still counts. And if it doesn't ring, hold me anyway. Thank you for listening, even in the silence between calls. Keep me ready, but not anxious. Amen.



TODAY

Pick up the phone and say out loud, as if answering, "Hello, this is" and your name. Add, "How can I help?" Say it twice, smiling the second time.

☐ DONE

What would I want my first words to be?

PSALM

66 — "God has listened": for a person who has been praying into silence.

177

DAY 177

The Coworker Who Wronged You

In the multitude of my thoughts within me, your comforts delight my soul.

PSALM 94:19 (WEB)

You've replayed it a hundred times. What they said, what you should have said, how it all went wrong. In the dark you win the argument, and in the morning you wake up tired.

That's what a grudge does. It makes you a worker without a paycheck. Unpaid overtime, in your own head. And nobody thanks you for the hours.

The psalmist says, "In the multitude of my thoughts within me." He knew that crowd. And in the middle of it he found something that quieted the room. Today we only clear one small thing out of that crowd.

Mother Mary, I keep going back to that conversation. The words are worn smooth. I'm tired of holding them. Take the old message out of my pocket. Quiet the voice that keeps replaying it. I'm not asking to feel warm toward them yet. I only ask to stop paying for it every night. Comfort me instead. Be near while I let go. Amen.



TODAY

Delete one old message, email, or text from that person or that job that keeps the hurt alive. Just one. Then breathe out slowly.

☐ DONE

What would I think about if I stopped replaying this?

PSALM

94 — "your comforts delight my soul": comfort in the middle of a crowded mind.



DAY 178

Offer the Day at Dawn

And whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men,

COLOSSIANS 3:23 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Before the day gets its hands on you, give it away. Say, this is yours. The errands, the calls, the dishes, the waiting, the worry.

There's an old practice of offering the day to God before your feet touch the floor. It takes ten seconds. It changes the shape of everything after, even the dull parts. A phone call becomes a gift. The mail becomes a small duty done well. Nothing is wasted if it was given.

Paul says whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord. He means the dishes, too. Especially the dishes.

This day is yours before it is mine, Lord. Take the morning, the tasks, the calls, the waiting. Take my hands and my mood. Let me do what's in front of me with a whole heart, and not grumble over the small parts. Whatever the hours bring, let me meet them as your gift. Start me gently. Amen.



TODAY

Stand, lift both arms as if holding the day, and lower them slowly while you say, "It's yours." Do it before you check anything else.

☐ DONE

What is the first thing I'll give him today?

PSALM

108 — "I will wake up the dawn": a psalm for a morning that has a purpose.

179

DAY 179

A Business of Kindness

So then, as we have opportunity, let's do what is good toward all men, and especially toward those who are of the household of the faith.

GALATIANS 6:10 (WEB)

Patricia and Dale closed their shop one year. With nothing left to sell, Dale started carrying candy in his pocket for the children waiting in line at the grocery. Patricia started noticing the quiet clerks. They told me it was the best business they ever ran. Nobody sent an invoice. Everybody went home better.

You can open the same business today. No license. No overhead. You already have the stock: a smile, a held door, an honest question.

Paul says, as we have opportunity. There's an opportunity in the very next line at the store.

Mary, make me a person who notices. The tired cashier. The woman counting her change. The man who only wanted someone to hold the door. Let me be generous with attention, which costs nothing. Open my eyes first, then my mouth. I may not have a job, but I have this hour. Use it however you like. Amen.



TODAY

Buy one small thing for someone else at the store, or just hold a door and say one kind sentence to a stranger.

☐ DONE

Who looked invisible to me this week, and why?

PSALM

34 — "Turn from evil and do good": a psalm for small kindnesses.



DAY 180

Credit You Never Got

so that your merciful deeds may be in secret, then your Father who sees in secret will reward you openly.

MATTHEW 6:4 (WEB)

Your name wasn't on the report. The idea you gave in the meeting came out of someone else's mouth. The thank-you never arrived. Maybe for twenty years you did the work behind the person who got the plaque.

I won't tell you it doesn't sting. It's one of the oldest hurts there is.

But listen to what Jesus says about deeds done in secret. Your Father sees in secret. That means someone was watching. Every late night, every quiet fix, every time you covered for somebody. None of it fell through the floor. It was seen, and he doesn't forget.

Lord, you saw. You saw the hours no one counted and the ideas that walked away without my name. I give you the sting of it. I don't need the plaque. I need to stop keeping score in my own head. Let your seeing be enough today. Let it be more than enough. Thank you for keeping the books. Amen.



TODAY

Write on a scrap of paper the credit you never got. Fold it small and tuck it inside a book you won't open for a week.

☐ DONE

Whose approval am I still waiting for, after all these years?

PSALM

75 — "We give thanks, for your Name is near": honor comes from him, not from the boss.

181

DAY 181

What Retirement Cannot Take

Therefore we don't faint, but though our outward person is decaying, yet our inward person is renewed day by day.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:16 (WEB)

Make a list of what retirement takes. The routine, the commute, the title, the people at the next desk, the sound of your name in a meeting. It's a long list, and I won't shorten it.

Now make another one, quietly: what it can't take. The way you tell a story. The way you love your family. Your skill with a pot or a pencil. Your prayers. Your name, written in God's memory.

Paul says the outer person is decaying, but the inner one is renewed day by day. Retirement is only outward. It never got to the part of you that is renewed.

Father, thank you for what is still mine. My memory, my hands, my voice, the people who call me by name. Let me not mourn only what was taken. Let me guard what remains. Renew me from the inside this morning, as you promise, and make me a good keeper of what I have left. Amen.



TODAY

Write the name of whoever first taught you your trade or showed you how to work. Thank God for them, out loud.

☐ DONE

What do I still have that no job ever gave me?

PSALM

92 — "fresh and green" in old age: what is inside doesn't retire.



DAY 182

Gratitude for the Last Job

We give thanks to you, God. We give thanks, for your Name is near. Men tell about your wondrous works.

PSALM 75:1 (WEB)

Before you close this door, thank it. I know that's a strange thing to ask. Maybe the job wasn't kind at the end. Maybe it let you go badly, or you left tired and bitter.

Still. It kept a roof over your family. It taught you things you didn't want to learn. It put you in rooms with people you'd never have met. It took years of mornings, and it gave something back.

Gratitude doesn't mean you liked it. It means you tell the truth about what you received. Thank God for the work, and your hands will feel lighter when you open them.

Lord, thank you for the work I did. For the hours, the lunches, the long drives, the lessons I learned the hard way. Thank you for the pay that fed my table, and for the people who stood beside me. I bless the place that held me, though it let me go. Free me to receive what comes next. Amen.



TODAY

Find a photograph of yourself from your working years, or simply picture one. Look at that face and say, "Thank you for showing up."

☐ DONE

What did that work make of me that I'm still glad of?

PSALM

9 — "I will give thanks with my whole heart": for the end of a long season of work.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

She doesn't tire, but you can forget she's there. A knot stays loose when you remember who is holding the other end. Come back tomorrow and say hello to her first.



DAY 183

The Open-Door Candle

I know your works (behold, I have set before you an open door, which no one can shut), that you have a little power, and kept my word, and didn't deny my name.

REVELATION 3:8 (WEB)

You've come to the last page of the month. Look how far you walked. You named a closed door. You asked for a next step. You counted your tools and your talents. You forgave a few people, or at least said their names. You knocked.

Mary doesn't promise which door opens, or when. She promises to stay at your elbow while you knock. And the Lord says, I have set before you an open door. He said it to people with a little power, who kept his word. That's you. A little power is enough to push.

Tonight, light the candle.

Mary, Undoer of Knots, thank you for this month. I don't know which door will open. Maybe a job, maybe a purpose, maybe only a better way to wait. Keep me knocking, keep me kind, keep me useful. Let me walk through whatever opens without fear. And when I forget, put your hand on my shoulder. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle and say its name aloud: "The Open Door." Say three names from your Names Page, then blow it out with "Amen."

☐ DONE

Which door am I willing to walk through next?

PSALM

118 — "Open to me the gates": the psalm for passing through.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The same tide that tied these knots is still out there. Don't fear it. Keep the candle where you can see it, and light it again on a slow morning. That's how you keep a door open.

LOOKING BACK AT THE MONTH

Four questions. Tick the box if the answer is yes, even a little.

1. ☐ Did I say out loud what the closed door was?

2. ☐ Did I do one useful thing for someone, paid or not?

3. ☐ Did I put down one hurt from work, even for a day?

4. ☐ Did I knock at least once more than I wanted to?

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS AT THE CLOSE OF THE MONTH

My friend,

You made it to the last page. I won't tell you the door has opened. I don't know that, and I'd never say what I don't know.

But look at your hands. They've held a tool, a phone, a candle, a name. They've given something away. They've forgiven a little. That is what hands do when a door is about to open.

Here is what I ask. Don't let this month tie itself up again. A knot you've loosened can tighten if you stop. Come back, even tired. Start with the next page, even on a slow morning. You did not do this alone. Mary is still at your elbow, and the Lord has kept the door where he put it.

Father Lucas



THE SEAL OF THE MONTH

A flat gold door, slightly ajar, with a thread of light on the floor beneath it. Around the edge: **THE OPEN DOOR · BOOK 6**. Date in your own hand:

THE CANDLE OF THE MONTH: THE OPEN DOOR

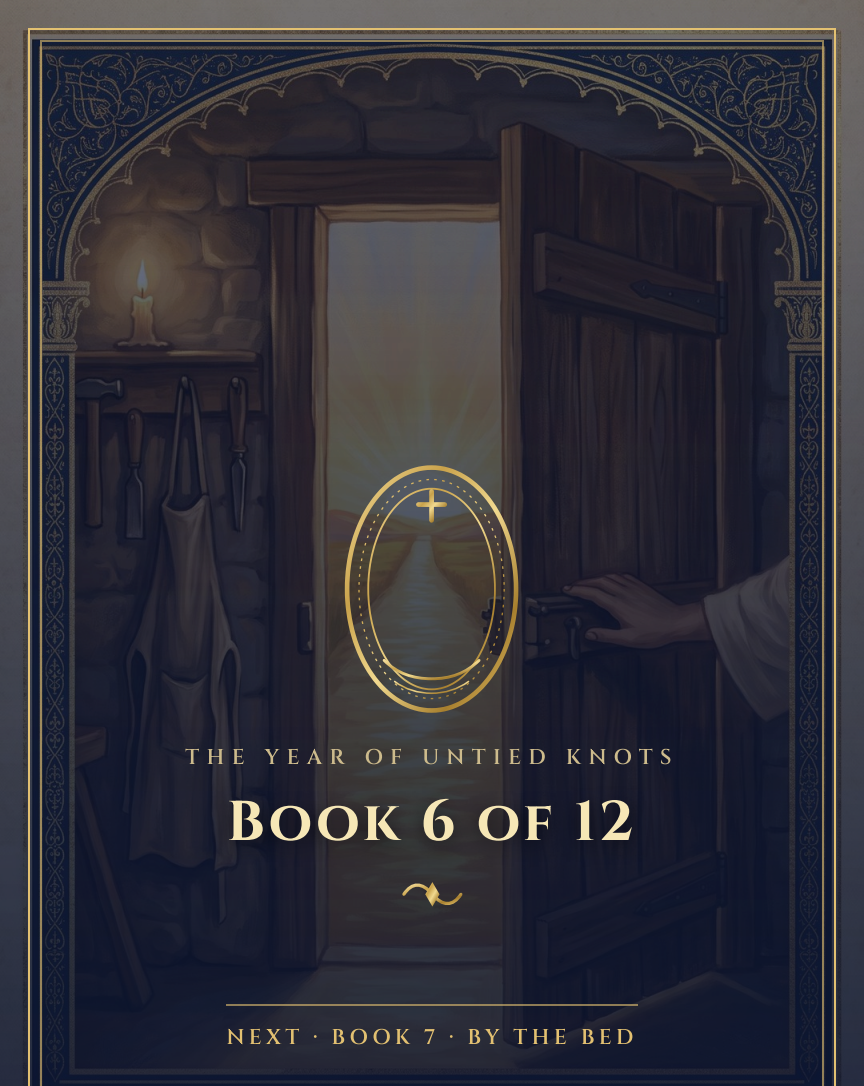
1. Light the candle and say its name: "The Open Door."
2. Say the names on your Names Page, one breath for each.
3. Blow it out and say, "Amen."

HALFWAY HOME

Half a year with Mary. The door you knocked on is not the door you started at.

Name:

Turn to Book 7 tomorrow.



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 6 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 7 · BY THE BED